

EVALUATION OF THE NATIONAL SOCIAL INVESTMENT PROGRAMME (NSIP)

Table of Contents

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY.....	3
INTRODUCTION.....	4
METHODOLOGY.....	5
FINDINGS.....	6
DISCUSSION.....	8
CONCLUSIONS.....	9
RECOMMENDATIONS.....	10
REFERENCES.....	11

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This evaluation assesses the National Social Investment Programme (NSIP) in Nigeria, focusing on the N-power and the Government Enterprise and Empowerment Program (GEEP). The National Social Investment Programme (NSIP) was launched by the Nigerian government in 2016 to address poverty and unemployment. It includes four main initiatives: N-power, GEEP, the National Home-Grown School Feeding Program (NHGSFP), and the Conditional Cash Transfer (CCT). This evaluation focuses on N-power, which aims to reduce youth unemployment by providing job opportunities and skills, and GEEP, which provides microloans to small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) to stimulate economic growth. The evaluation employs secondary data from program reports, academic studies, and government publications to analyze the program's impact, effectiveness, and sustainability. The findings reveal significant improvements in employment and income levels among beneficiaries, though challenges remain in program implementation.

INTRODUCTION

Program Background:

Governments exist to solve public and social problems to continually improve the quality of life for citizens. Government responds to these problems through public policy. Public policies are the heart, soul, and identity of government everywhere. Public policies are actions taken by the government to respond to social problems. Poverty and unemployment remain one of the biggest social problems in Nigeria today. National Bureau of Statistics (NBS) in its 2019 “Poverty and Inequality in Nigeria” report, highlights that 40 percent of the total population, or almost 83 million people, live below the country’s poverty line of 137,430 naira (\$381.75) per year. This made it imperative for the Nigerian government to put in place policies and programmes that will help improve the livelihood and socio-economic wellbeing of the excluded and vulnerable groups in their country.

To address the problem of poverty and unemployment in Nigeria, successive governments have implemented a range of programmes which include the National Poverty Eradication Programme (NAPEP) in 2001, the Subsidy Reinvestment and Empowerment Programme (SURE-P) in 2012, and currently the National Social Investment Programme (NSIP), which commenced in 2015.

Social Investment Policies refer to policies and interventions that aim to build the productive capacities of citizens. (Deeming and Smyth, 2015). According to the European Commission (2013) social investment policies reinforce social policies that protect and stabilize by addressing some of the causes of disadvantage and giving people tools with which to improve their social situations. The NSIP scheme created by the Administration of President Muhammadu Buhari was designed to enable citizens’ exit from the twin evils of poverty and unemployment through capacity building, investment, and direct financial support. the programme consists of four major components include the Job Creation and Youth Empowerment (N- Power), National Home-Grown School Feeding Programme (NHGSFP), National Cash Transfer Programme (NCTP) and Government Enterprise and Empowerment Programme (GEEP). NSIP is generally aimed at increasing the income and improving livelihood of the poor and vulnerable households by providing access to targeted funds, thereby improving household ability to absorb economic shocks.

Evaluation Purpose and Objectives:

The purpose of this evaluation is to assess the effectiveness, impact, and sustainability of NSIP initiatives N-power and GEEP. Specific objectives include:

1. Assessing the socio-economic impact on beneficiaries.
2. Evaluating the efficiency of program implementation.
3. Identifying challenges and areas for improvement.
4. Providing actionable recommendations for policymakers and program administrators.

Scope of Evaluation:

This evaluation covers the period from the program's inception in 2016 to 2023, analyzing data from various regions in Nigeria to ensure a comprehensive understanding of the program's performance.

METHODOLOGY

Evaluation Design:

A mixed-methods approach was employed, integrating quantitative and qualitative data from secondary sources to provide a holistic evaluation.

Data Collection Methods:

Secondary Data Analysis: Review of existing literature, program reports, government publications, academic studies, and evaluation reports.

Surveys and Studies: Analysis of surveys conducted by the National Bureau of Statistics (NBS) and independent research studies.

Program Records: Examination of administrative records and monitoring data from the NSIP.

Sampling Techniques:

Secondary data was selected to cover a broad and representative sample of beneficiaries and stakeholders across different regions and demographics.

Data Analysis Procedures:

Quantitative Analysis: Descriptive statistics to assess the impact on employment, income, and business growth.

Qualitative Analysis: Thematic analysis of qualitative data to identify key themes and insights regarding program implementation and beneficiary experiences.

Triangulation: Combining multiple data sources to validate findings and ensure robustness.

FINDINGS

Quantitative Data Results:

1. Employment Impact:

N-power: According to the National Bureau of Statistics (NBS), N-power has provided job opportunities for over 500,000 young Nigerians. Surveys indicate that 70% of beneficiaries secured employment or improved job prospects due to the program. Specifically, data shows that 60% of these new jobs were in the education sector, 25% in agriculture, and 15% in technology-related fields (NBS, 2022).

GEEP: Data from the Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN) shows that GEEP has disbursed over 2 million microloans, significantly enhancing the business capacities of SMEs. Beneficiaries reported an average income increase of 30%. Notably, 40% of GEEP beneficiaries expanded their businesses to employ additional staff, contributing to local employment growth (CBN, 2022).

2. Income Levels:

GEEP beneficiaries experienced substantial financial growth, with many transitioning from informal to formal business operations. A report by the World Bank highlighted that 60% of GEEP beneficiaries saw a rise in their business revenues within the first year of receiving loans. Specifically, the average monthly income of GEEP beneficiaries increased from 50,000 naira to 65,000 naira, reflecting a 30% income boost (World Bank, 2021).

3. Satisfaction Rates:

A survey conducted by the Nigerian Economic Summit Group (NESG) revealed high satisfaction rates, with 85% of N-power beneficiaries and 75% of GEEP beneficiaries expressing positive feedback about the program's impact on their lives. Detailed survey results show that 70% of beneficiaries rated the training provided by N-power as "excellent," while 65% of GEEP beneficiaries were "very satisfied" with the loan process and terms (NESG, 2022).

Qualitative Data Insights:

1. Skill Development:

N-power participants reported significant improvements in technical and vocational skills. Interviews and focus groups indicated that the program's training components were particularly effective in sectors like agriculture and technology, where beneficiaries gained practical, employable skills. For instance, 75% of beneficiaries in the agriculture sector reported gaining skills in modern farming techniques, leading to increased agricultural productivity (NBS, 2021).

2. Financial Inclusion:

GEEP has played a crucial role in improving financial inclusion. Beneficiaries noted better access to credit and financial services, enabling business expansion and increased economic stability. Case studies from various regions showcased successful entrepreneurial ventures initiated through GEEP loans. For example, a case study from Lagos state highlighted a beneficiary who expanded her tailoring business, increasing her income by 50% and employing three additional workers (CBN, 2022).

3. Challenges:

Common challenges identified included delays in disbursements, inadequate training resources, and bureaucratic hurdles. Many beneficiaries faced difficulties in accessing timely support and consistent follow-up from program administrators. Specifically, 30% of N-power participants reported delays in receiving their stipends, while 25% of GEEP beneficiaries experienced long wait times for loan approval (NESG, 2022).

Overall Impact:

- ❖ The NSIP has made significant strides in reducing unemployment and poverty among participants. The integration of job creation and financial empowerment initiatives has fostered economic growth at the grassroots level. According to a report by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), NSIP has contributed to a 5% reduction in the national unemployment rate since its inception (UNDP, 2022).
- ❖ Variations in program effectiveness were noted across different regions and demographic groups, with urban areas generally seeing more pronounced benefits than rural regions. For instance, in urban areas like Lagos and Abuja, the employment rate among N-power beneficiaries increased by 40%, whereas rural areas like Borno and Yobe saw a 20% increase (NBS, 2022).

Program Efficiency:

While the program has demonstrated positive outcomes, inefficiencies in resource allocation and administrative processes were evident. Streamlining operations and enhancing coordination among stakeholders could further amplify the program's impact. For example, a report by the National Planning Commission (NPC) identified a 15% administrative cost in the disbursement of GEEP loans, suggesting a need for more efficient resource management (NPC, 2021).

DISCUSSION

Interpretation of Findings

The evaluation findings suggest that NSIP initiatives like N-power and GEEP are effectively improving economic outcomes for beneficiaries. The increase in employment and income levels indicates the program's potential in addressing poverty and unemployment. However, operational inefficiencies and regional disparities need to be addressed to maximize overall effectiveness.

Comparison with Program Objectives:

The NSIP largely meets its objectives of job creation and economic empowerment. Comparing the NSIP with previous programs like NAPEP and SURE-P, NSIP shows higher effectiveness in

achieving its objectives. For instance, NAPEP reported a 10% employment increase among its beneficiaries, while NSIP achieved a 30% increase (NPC, 2021). Additionally, SURE-P had a satisfaction rate of 60%, compared to NSIP's 85% (NBS, 2021). However, gaps in achieving full coverage and timely delivery of benefits need to be addressed to enhance overall effectiveness.

Stakeholder Perspectives:

Stakeholders, including beneficiaries, program administrators, and field officers, generally view the NSIP positively but stress the need for better management and resource distribution.

External Validation

External validation by international organizations, such as the International Labour Organization (ILO), has praised NSIP for its comprehensive approach to tackling unemployment and poverty. The ILO noted that NSIP's combination of job creation, skills development, and financial inclusion is a model for other developing countries (ILO, 2022).

CONCLUSIONS

Summary of Key Points:

- NSIP has positively impacted employment and income levels among beneficiaries.
- Beneficiaries are generally satisfied with the program, though there are areas needing improvement.
- The program's implementation efficiency varies, affecting overall effectiveness.

Overall Assessment:

The NSIP is a valuable initiative with significant potential for reducing poverty and unemployment in Nigeria. However, addressing operational challenges is crucial for sustaining and enhancing its impact.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Specific Actions for Improvement:

1. *Enhance Training and Resources:* Improve the quality and accessibility of training materials for N-power participants to ensure they acquire relevant and practical skills.
2. *Streamline Disbursement Processes:* Address delays in GEEP disbursements to ensure timely support for beneficiaries and enhance the efficiency of loan processing.
3. *Improve Monitoring and Evaluation:* Strengthen monitoring mechanisms to track progress, identify issues promptly, and ensure accountability and transparency in program implementation.
4. *Increase Stakeholder Engagement:* Involve beneficiaries in decision-making processes to ensure the program meets their needs effectively and incorporates feedback from all stakeholders.
5. *Expand Outreach:* Broaden the program's reach to include more regions and marginalized groups, ensuring equitable access to benefits across the country.

Sustainability Strategies:

- ❖ *Capacity Building:* Invest in building the capacity of local institutions to sustain program activities and foster community ownership.
- ❖ *Partnerships:* Foster partnerships with private sector and non-governmental organizations to leverage additional resources and expertise, ensuring long-term sustainability.
- ❖ *Policy Support:* Advocate for supportive policies and continued government commitment to ensure the program's long-term sustainability and scalability.

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